unity when leaders from the eastern province differed on major issues with the leaders from the northern region.

Jayewardene's government repeatedly promised fair treatment to all communities irrespective of language, race or religion. Against this background M. Canagaratnam, member of parliament from Pottuvil in the eastern province, crossed to the treasury benches. Subsequently an attempt was made on his life, presumably by Tamil terrorists. On 7 September 19 78, an hour before the formal promulgation of Sri Lanka's new constitution, the youths of the Tiger Liberation Movement blew up an Avro aircraft belonging to Air Ceylon at Rat-malana airport near Colombo to protest the lack of independence to a Tamil Eelam. The act was allegedly carried out by two Tamil youths who had travelled by the same aircraft from Jaffna.

Anyone suspected of having helped the police was brutally killed by the young terrorists. The TULF officially disowned any responsibility for these violent acts and also declared that they had nothing to do with the terrorist movement. The youth wing of the TULF however, was increasingly restive over the slow pace towards the achievement of an independent Tamil Eelam. Though the senior leadership argued that nothing could be achieved by violence, the young Tamils were impatient. India watched the developments cautiously. In 1978, the Indian High Commission with Thomas Abraham at the helm of affairs had thirty-nine Indian staff and seventy-two locals. On 17 August 1981, an emergency was imposed on the country following violent attacks on Tamils in the estate areas. The emergency lapsed on 16 January 1982. Some pro-Tamil leaders believed that a lasting Eelam could not achieved by fireworks set off in London. In February 1982 the dissidents of the TULF group christened themselves the Tamil Eelam Liberation Front.